Reducing Your Risk of Dementia

National Institute on Aging

Healthy Lifestyle Choices That May Help Lower Your Risk of Dementia

Dementia is the loss of the ability to think, remember, and reason to such an extent that it interferes with a person's daily life and activities. As you age, you may wonder if there is anything you can do to reduce your risk of dementia.

Many factors may influence your risk of developing dementia. While some of these factors, such as your age, genetics, and environment, are beyond your control, there may be steps you can take to address other factors that may lower your risk. Some studies have shown that people with healthy lifestyle behaviors tend to have a lower risk of dementia. While these findings are promising, scientists still need to test these healthy lifestyle behaviors in clinical trials to determine if they can prevent or delay dementia.

Understanding how lifestyle choices are related to dementia risk is important for your health. Small behavior changes can add up, and making them part of your routine can support your brain health now and in the future.

What Can You Do?

Although there is no proven way to prevent dementia, in general, leading a healthy lifestyle may help lower your chances of developing dementia as you age. To support your brain health and help reduce your risk of dementia, you can:

Control high blood pressure. High blood pressure can harm your heart, blood vessels, and brain, and may increase your risk of stroke and vascular dementia. Getting your blood pressure checked at your doctor's office is important because many people with high blood pressure feel fine. To control high blood pressure, your doctor may recommend medication or lifestyle changes, such as exercising more, eating healthy foods, and quitting smoking.

Manage blood sugar. Higher than normal levels of blood sugar, or glucose, can lead to diabetes and may increase your risk of heart disease, stroke, cognitive impairment, and dementia. Making healthy food choices, getting regular exercise, quitting smoking, and checking glucose levels can help you manage blood sugar levels.

Eat a healthy diet. Many studies suggest that what we eat affects the aging brain's ability to think and remember. Healthy eating patterns that incorporate fruits, vegetables, whole grains, and lean protein sources have been linked to cognitive benefits in some, but not all, studies. More research is needed — and is underway — to determine if what we eat can help prevent or delay Alzheimer's disease or age-related cognitive decline.

Be physically active. Physical activity has many health benefits, such as reducing the risk of depression, diabetes, high blood pressure, and stroke — health conditions that can contribute to age-related cognitive decline. Certain types of exercise can also help prevent muscle loss and reduce your risk of falling, which can injure your brain. Aim for 150 to 300 minutes of moderate-intensity physical activity plus two days of muscle-strengthening exercise each week.

Keep mentally active. Many activities can help keep your mind active, including reading, playing board games, crafting, taking up a new hobby, learning a new skill, working or volunteering, and socializing.

Stay connected with family and friends. Connecting with people and engaging in social activities can prevent social isolation and loneliness. Staying connected with your family, friends, and neighbors is an important way to support your cognitive health as you age.

Treat hearing problems. Hearing loss may affect cognition and dementia risk in older adults and can make it more difficult to interact with others. Protect your ears from loud sounds to help prevent hearing loss. Get your hearing tested and use hearing aids if your doctor recommends them.

Take care of your mental and physical health. This includes getting recommended health screenings, managing chronic health issues such as depression or high cholesterol, quitting smoking, and regularly checking in with a health care provider.

Sleep well. Sleeping well is important for both your mind and body. Try to get seven to nine hours of sleep each night. Talk with your doctor if you are not getting enough sleep, are sleeping poorly, or think you may have a sleep disorder.

Prevent falls. The risk of falling — and fall-related problems — rises with age. Falling can lead to serious injury, including injuries to the brain. However, many falls can be prevented. Take steps to prevent falls by fall-proofing your home and wearing shoes with nonskid soles that fully support your feet.

Limit or avoid alcohol. Drinking too much alcohol can lead to falls and may make certain health conditions worse, including diabetes, high blood pressure, stroke, memory loss, and mood disorders. Experts recommend that men should not have more than two drinks a day and women only one.

While researchers do not know for certain whether making these lifestyle changes will protect against dementia, all are good for your health and are part of making healthy choices as you age.

Dementia Prevention Research: How Can You Help?

More research is needed to find ways to help prevent Alzheimer's and related dementias. You can help researchers learn more about preventing dementia by participating in clinical trials and studies. Search the Alzheimers.gov Clinical Trials Finder at **www.alzheimers.gov/clinical-trials** to find studies in need of volunteers.

For More Information

NIA Alzheimer's and Related Dementias Education and Referral (ADEAR) Center

800-438-4380

adear@nia.nih.gov

www.nia.nih.gov/alzheimers

The NIA ADEAR Center offers information and free print publications about Alzheimer's and related dementias for families, caregivers, and health professionals. ADEAR Center staff answer telephone, email, and written requests and make referrals to local and national resources.

Alzheimers.gov

www.alzheimers.gov

Explore the Alzheimers.gov portal for information and resources on Alzheimer's and related dementias from across the federal government.

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